Barcelona Travel Guide

Gaudi, beaches and tapas on the Mediterranean - Spain

Barcelona: Overview and History

Barcelona is the capital of Catalonia, a region in north-east Spain, and lies on the Mediterranean Sea. The Romans founded the town of Barcino here in the first century BC, and remains of its Roman walls can still be seen in the Gothic Quarter. Like London and Paris, Barcelona was once part of the Roman Empire ruled from Rome.

In the Middle Ages Barcelona became a powerful trading port. In the nineteenth century the city grew rapidly and the engineer Ildefons Cerda designed the Eixample district, a grid of wide streets with cut-off corners at each block.

At the end of the nineteenth century, the Catalan Modernisme movement transformed the city. Its most famous architect, Antoni Gaudi, created fantastic buildings with curving shapes and colourful mosaics. Barcelona hosted the Summer Olympic Games in 1992, which brought new beaches and a modern waterfront.

Two languages are spoken in Barcelona: Catalan and Spanish. Signs are usually in Catalan first.

Barcelona: Top Attractions

The Sagrada Familia is Gaudi's masterpiece, a giant basilica begun in 1882 that is still under construction more than 140 years later. Its interior columns branch like trees and its stained glass fills the space with coloured light. Tickets should be booked in advance.

Park Guell is a hillside park designed by Gaudi with a famous mosaic lizard, a serpentine bench and views over the city. On the Passeig de Gracia avenue you can visit two more Gaudi houses: Casa Batllo, with a roof like a dragon's back, and Casa Mila, also known as La Pedrera.

La Rambla is a long tree-lined pedestrian street leading down to the sea. Halfway along is La Boqueria, a famous food market. The Gothic Quarter (Barri Gotic) is a maze of medieval streets around Barcelona Cathedral.

Montjuic hill offers museums, gardens and the 1992 Olympic stadium, and Barceloneta beach is the most popular city beach. Football fans can visit Camp Nou, the home stadium of FC Barcelona.

Barcelona: Neighborhoods and Food

El Born is a stylish area with boutiques, cocktail bars and the Picasso Museum, which holds many works from the artist's early years. Gracia feels like a village, with small squares full of cafes and a big neighbourhood festival in August. The Eixample is home to many Modernisme buildings and elegant shops.

Barceloneta, the old fishermen's quarter by the beach, is the place for seafood restaurants. Poble Sec is known for its street of tapas bars, Carrer de Blai, where small snacks called pintxos are sold at low prices.

Catalan food is a highlight. Pa amb tomaquet is bread rubbed with ripe tomato, olive oil and salt. Tapas such as patatas bravas, croquetas and jamon iberico are perfect for sharing. Paella, originally from Valencia, is popular by the sea, and crema catalana is a local custard dessert similar to creme brulee.

Locals enjoy vermouth before lunch on weekends and cava, Catalan sparkling wine. Meals are eaten late: lunch at around 2 pm and dinner at 9 or 10 pm.

Barcelona: Getting Around and Practical Tips

Barcelona has an efficient Metro run by TMB, plus buses and trams. The T-casual card gives ten journeys, and the Hola Barcelona travel card offers unlimited travel for visitors. The city centre is also easy to explore on foot or by bicycle.

Barcelona-El Prat Airport is about 15 kilometres from the centre. The Aerobus shuttle reaches Placa de Catalunya in about 35 minutes, and Metro line L9 also serves the airport.

High-speed AVE trains connect Barcelona Sants with Madrid in about 2 hours 30 minutes, and TGV trains run to Paris Gare de Lyon in about six and a half hours. The currency is the euro (EUR).

The best time to visit Barcelona is late spring, May and June, or September, when the sea is warm and the big La Merce festival takes place in late September. July and August are hot and very busy. Watch out for pickpockets on La Rambla and in the Metro.

Barcelona: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Visit the Sagrada Familia in the morning, then walk along the Passeig de Gracia to see Casa Batllo and Casa Mila. Spend the evening in the Gothic Quarter. Day 2: Explore Park Guell in the morning, have lunch at La Boqueria, and relax on Barceloneta beach.

Day 3: Visit the Picasso Museum and El Born, then take the cable car up Montjuic for sunset views.

The mountain monastery of Montserrat, home of the Black Madonna, is about one hour away by train and rack railway. Sitges is a pretty beach town 40 minutes south. The medieval city of Girona and the Dali Theatre-Museum in Figueres, created by the surrealist artist Salvador Dali, make a great day out.

Barcelona is often combined with Paris on a rail trip, or with Rome by flight or overnight ferry.